

Episode 78: Once Upon a Time... (49) – Location Scouting!

Lately I've been approached by young people in the industry at various places saying things like "I'm reading your Anime Style series!" or "I'm watching *Casshern*!"

Oh my (sweat).

Despite how I look, I'm actually quite shy (laughs). While I can have perfectly relaxed, normal, enthusiastic, and enjoyable conversations with people I've met several times before, when young people, especially young women, approach me at studios or other places, I get quite surprised and flustered.

Just recently someone spoke to me at a certain studio, but I got so flustered that I don't think I gave proper responses...

At that time (and pretty much always), I was walking around lost in thought, completely defenceless when someone spoke to me, so I was surprised and flustered (sweat).

Since someone took the trouble to speak to me, I wish I could have given at least one witty response. Sorry about that > you at that time

Oh well...

But you know, I'm actually quite happy about it (laughs). Thank you everyone. Getting such reactions is tremendously encouraging (laughs).

So I'll do my best not to drop manuscripts... *cough cough* ...as much as possible (heavy sweat).

Now then.

Coo: Far From Home had begun, but we were in days of waiting for the scenario, then waiting for storyboards. I think at this point the planned theatrical release was summer of the following year (1993), so it was still over a year away.

One year later!

I had never worked on a production with such a long schedule until completion. It was always "No time!" or "One month until delivery!" - that kind of thing. TV series end up taking about a year, but that's making one episode per week for a year, and each individual episode was always about how to fight and win with limited time each week. It was that kind of repetition.

"*Coo: Far From Home* will take proper production time and be made using Toei's original method for theatrical features!" These were the words of Kaburaki-san, who was commanding COO's production at the time.

Hearing that and reflecting, the first theatrical work I was involved with at Toei Animation (東映動画) was the legendary *Odin*, which was made by somehow finishing it with absolutely no time, and the theatrical *Fist of the North Star* (北斗の拳) and *TRANSFORMERS THE MOVIE* (American co-production) that I helped with were also large in scale but created relatively quickly in a rush, and the *Saint Seiya* theatrical versions and *GeGeGe no Kitaro* that I handled as main staff were ultimately only on the production scale of extensions of "Toei Manga Festival."

Since we didn't even know about the era of *Galaxy Express 999* and such, I remember being a bit moved by the words "make it using Toei's original method for theatrical features."

So the stance was to first take proper time on storyboards and settings, and do solid foundation work.

Therefore, character design worked on character designs, art director worked on art settings - everyone was steadily advancing their basic setting work. Meanwhile, I was starting to create colour samples from the character designs that came up, while fighting with that year's second *Dragon Ball Z* theatrical version, and losing my mother to cancer (tears).

"Let's go on location scouting!"

It was around the time the calendar was about to turn to July when this talk suddenly arose.

"Huh? Location scouting? The South Pacific? (hopeful)"

"Mm, Aburatsubo."

"...Ah, Aburatsubo? (sweat)"

"Cruisers and such, you really need to see proper ones once, in person. It's hard to draw storyboards without really understanding them," said Director Imazawa. The storyboard work and setting work were still in progress, but he seemed to be stuck.

Furthermore... "Dolphins and such, you really need to see proper ones once, in person. It's hard to draw storyboards without really understanding them," so considering various things together, we decided to go location scouting to Aburatsubo on the Miura Peninsula in Kanagawa Prefecture, not far from Tokyo.

Location scouting! What a fun-sounding word (laughs). I think this was my first location scouting. I'll confess - at this time, I was honestly half in field trip mode (laughs). While we were heading to Aburatsubo in two cars from Tokyo, I was just feeling "fun" for no particular reason, all floaty.

I didn't yet understand the significance of location scouting. If we just wanted to see cruisers or dolphins, each of us could have gone separately. But you know, having all the staff look at the same things while talking, exchanging opinions about settings and visuals - sharing such occasions and time is important for everyone working together to create one work.

"Ah, this is what location scouting is about"

On the deck of a large cruiser moored at Aburatsubo Marina, talking with Director Imazawa, Yamamoto Nizo-san, Okura-san and others while imagining actual scenes from the main story, I thought "I see, this is what location scouting is."

After that we moved to Aburatsubo Marine Park to observe dolphins and other marine life. There too, while watching the dolphins swim, everyone's opinions flew around. It was really nice. Location scouting really is important!

And the end of that Aburatsubo location scouting was extending our trip to Misaki Port for everyone to eat together. Misaki Port means tuna! We had delicious tuna at a restaurant run by the local fishermen's cooperative. Ending with everyone eating delicious food together - this too is an important point of location scouting (laughs).

(09.02.10)